UNIT II - VOCABULARY BUILDING AND PRONUNCIATION

Vocabulary is the stock of words you know and use. A wide vocabulary lets you express exact meanings, understand what you hear and read, and sound confident. **Pronunciation** is how you say those words. Good speech needs both: the right word, said the right way.

1. Word Formation

New words are made from existing words by several processes. Knowing them lets you work out the meaning of unfamiliar words.

(a) Affixation: prefixes and suffixes

An **affix** is a group of letters added to a base (root) word. A **prefix** comes before it and usually changes the meaning; a **suffix** comes after it and usually changes the part of speech.

Prefix	Meaning	Examples
un-, in-, im-, il-, ir-, non-	not	unhappy, incorrect, impossible, illegal, irregular, nonsense
dis-, mis-	opposite, wrongly	disagree, dislike, misunderstand, misuse
re-	again	rewrite, rebuild, return
pre-	before	preview, prepare, prehistoric
post-	after	postpone, postgraduate
sub-	under	submarine, subway
inter-	between	international, interval
anti-	against	antibiotic, anti-social
over-, under-	too much, too little	overeat, underestimate
bi-, tri-, multi-	two, three, many	bicycle, triangle, multinational

Suffix	Makes	Examples
-ness, -ment, -tion, -sion, -ity, -ship, -hood, -ance, -ence	nouns	kindness, achievement, creation, decision, ability, friendship, childhood, importance
-er, -or, -ist, -ian	person who does	teacher, actor, artist, musician
-ful, -ous, -ive, -al, -ic, -able, -ible, -less, -y	adjectives	careful, famous, active, national, heroic, readable, careless, rainy
-ly	adverbs	quickly, happily
-ize / -ise, -en, -ify	verbs	modernize, strengthen, simplify

(b) Other methods

- **Compounding:** two words joined: sun + flower = sunflower; black + board = blackboard; mother-in-law.
- **Conversion:** a word changes its part of speech without changing form: a *drink* (noun) - to *drink* (verb).
- **Blending:** parts of two words: breakfast + lunch = brunch; smoke + fog = smog; motor + hotel = motel.
- **Clipping:** shortening: examination - exam; telephone - phone; influenza - flu.

- **Acronyms:** initial letters pronounced as a word: NASA, UNESCO, laser, radar.
- **Borrowing:** words taken from other languages: bungalow, shampoo, jungle (Indian languages); restaurant (French).

2. Synonyms and Antonyms

Synonyms

Synonyms are words with the same or nearly the same meaning. No two synonyms are exactly alike: they may differ in formality, strength or usage. *Begin* and *commence* mean the same, but *commence* is more formal. Using synonyms avoids repetition and makes speech richer.

Word	Synonyms	Word	Synonyms
Brave	courageous, bold, fearless	Happy	joyful, cheerful, glad
Rapid	quick, fast, swift	Big	large, huge, enormous
Ancient	old, antique, archaic	Smart	clever, intelligent, bright
Generous	liberal, kind, charitable	Begin	start, commence, initiate
Permit	allow, let, authorise	Help	assist, aid, support
Victory	triumph, success, win	Tired	exhausted, weary, fatigued
Create	make, build, produce	Angry	furious, irate, annoyed

Antonyms

Antonyms are words with opposite meanings. They are of three kinds:

- **Gradable:** hot - cold (with levels in between, like warm and cool).
- **Complementary:** alive - dead, true - false (one excludes the other).
- **Relational:** buy - sell, teacher - student, parent - child.

Word	Antonym	Word	Antonym
Brave	cowardly	Increase	decrease
Rapid	slow	Accept	reject
Ancient	modern	Success	failure
Generous	stingy, selfish	Victory	defeat
Permit	forbid, prohibit	Create	destroy
Honest	dishonest	Arrive	depart
Strong	weak	Knowledge	ignorance

Making antonyms with prefixes: happy - unhappy, possible - impossible, legal - illegal, regular - irregular, agree - disagree, honest - dishonest. Not all words follow this rule (the opposite of 'good' is 'bad', not 'ungood'), so learn them as pairs.

3. Homonyms

Homonyms are words that are the same in sound, in spelling, or in both, but different in meaning. The group includes **homophones**, **homographs** and **homonyms proper**.

(a) Homophones: same sound, different spelling and meaning

Words	Meanings
to / too / two	towards / also, excessively / the number 2
there / their / they're	in that place / belonging to them / they are
write / right / rite	put words on paper / correct, opposite of left / ceremony
piece / peace	a part / calm, freedom from war
principal / principle	head of a school, main / a rule or belief
site / sight / cite	a place / ability to see / to quote
wear / where	to put on clothes / in which place
weak / week	not strong / seven days
knew / new	past of know / not old
break / brake	to damage / a stopping device
hear / here	listen with ears / in this place
stationary / stationery	not moving / writing materials

(b) Homographs: same spelling, different meaning (and sometimes sound)

Word	Meaning 1	Meaning 2
bear	an animal	to carry or tolerate
bat	a flying animal	an instrument used in cricket
lead (led)	to guide	(led) a metal
tear (tair)	to rip	(teer) a drop from the eye
row	a line of things	a quarrel
bank	a financial institution	the side of a river
light	not heavy	brightness

(c) Homonyms proper: same sound and same spelling, different meaning

Bark (the sound of a dog / the covering of a tree); *left* (opposite of right / past of leave); *watch* (to look at / a wristwatch); *ring* (a circle of metal worn on a finger / to sound a bell).

Tip: Use each pair in a sentence to remember it: *I want to go there to see their house, but they're away.*

4. One-Word Substitutes

One word can replace a whole phrase or clause. This makes speech and writing crisp and is a very common test item.

Phrase	One word
A person who writes his own life story	Autobiographer (the book: autobiography)
A person who loves books	Bibliophile
One who does not believe in God	Atheist
One who believes in God	Theist
One who hates mankind	Misanthrope

Phrase	One word
One who is always hopeful	Optimist
One who always sees the dark side	Pessimist
A child whose parents are dead	Orphan
A man whose wife has died	Widower
One who walks on foot	Pedestrian
One who eats both plants and meat	Omnivore
One who eats only plants	Herbivore
One who eats human flesh	Cannibal
One who speaks many languages	Polyglot
One who cannot read or write	Illiterate
That which cannot be read (handwriting)	Illegible
That which cannot be believed	Incredible
That which cannot be avoided	Inevitable
That which is present everywhere	Omnipresent
One who knows everything	Omniscient
Government by the people	Democracy
Government by one person with total power	Dictatorship / Autocracy
A place where birds are kept	Aviary
A place where books are kept	Library
A place where animals are kept for show	Zoo
Fear of open spaces	Agoraphobia
Fear of closed spaces	Claustrophobia
Study of birds	Ornithology
A speech delivered without preparation	Extempore
A medicine that kills germs	Antiseptic
A person who is new to a task or field	Novice
A person who is expert at judging art or food	Connoisseur

5. Changing One Part of Speech to Another

Many English words have related forms in different parts of speech. Changing the form helps you use the right word in the right place. Use suffixes and small spelling changes.

Noun	Verb	Adjective	Adverb
beauty	beautify	beautiful	beautifully
success	succeed	successful	successfully
decision	decide	decisive	decisively
strength	strengthen	strong	strongly

Noun	Verb	Adjective	Adverb
pleasure	please	pleasant	pleasantly
knowledge	know	knowledgeable	knowledgeably
difference	differ	different	differently
care	care	careful	carefully
danger	endanger	dangerous	dangerously
choice	choose	choosy	-
growth	grow	grown	-
energy	energise	energetic	energetically

Examples in sentences

1. He is a **success** (noun). He wants to **succeed** (verb). He is a **successful** man (adjective). He did the work **successfully** (adverb).
2. Her **kindness** (noun) shows that she is **kind** (adjective) and acts **kindly** (adverb).

6. Odd-One-Out

In an odd-one-out exercise, you find the word that does not belong to a group. To solve it:

- Find what the other words have in common (meaning, category, part of speech, spelling pattern or sound).
- Check whether the group is about synonyms, categories (fruits, cities), parts of speech or spelling/sound.
- The word that breaks the pattern is the odd one.

Examples

1. Apple, mango, carrot, banana - **carrot** (a vegetable; others are fruits).
2. Happy, joyful, cheerful, sad - **sad** (others are synonyms).
3. Run, jump, walk, table - **table** (a noun; others are verbs).
4. Chennai, Madurai, Delhi, Coimbatore - **Delhi** (not in Tamil Nadu).
5. Quick, rapid, swift, slow - **slow** (an antonym of the rest).
6. Cut, hut, nut, put - **put** (pronounced with a different vowel sound).

7. Idioms and Phrases

An **idiom** is a fixed expression whose meaning is different from the meaning of its separate words. You cannot understand *kick the bucket* (to die) by looking at 'kick' and 'bucket'. A **phrase** here means a fixed group of words, such as a phrasal verb. Idioms make speech lively and natural, but they should not be changed or translated word for word.

Idiom	Meaning	Example
A piece of cake	Very easy	The test was a piece of cake.
Break the ice	Start a conversation in an awkward situation	He told a joke to break the ice.
Once in a blue moon	Very rarely	We meet once in a blue moon.

Idiom	Meaning	Example
Spill the beans	Reveal a secret	Don't spill the beans about the party.
Hit the nail on the head	Say or do exactly the right thing	You hit the nail on the head.
Burn the midnight oil	Work late at night	She burnt the midnight oil before exams.
Under the weather	Slightly unwell	I am feeling under the weather.
Cost an arm and a leg	Very expensive	That phone cost an arm and a leg.
Let the cat out of the bag	Reveal a secret by mistake	He let the cat out of the bag.
Bite the bullet	Face a difficult situation bravely	I had to bite the bullet and ask for help.
Call it a day	Stop working for the day	It's late; let's call it a day.
Cry over spilt milk	Worry about something that cannot be changed	It is useless to cry over spilt milk.
Face the music	Accept punishment or consequences	He had to face the music.
In hot water	In trouble	He is in hot water with his boss.
On cloud nine	Extremely happy	She was on cloud nine after the result.
The ball is in your court	It is your turn to decide	I have made my offer; the ball is in your court.
Beat around the bush	Avoid the main point	Don't beat around the bush; tell me.
Add fuel to the fire	Make a bad situation worse	His remark added fuel to the fire.

Phrasal verbs

A phrasal verb is a verb + particle (preposition or adverb) with a special meaning:

Phrasal verb	Meaning	Example
give up	stop trying	Never give up.
look after	take care of	She looks after her grandmother.
look forward to	wait eagerly for	I look forward to the trip.
put off	postpone	They put off the meeting.
turn down	refuse	He turned down the offer.
carry on	continue	Carry on with your work.
break down	stop working	The car broke down.
run out of	have none left	We ran out of milk.

8. Joining Sentences

Joining short sentences into longer ones removes choppiness and shows how ideas are related. There are four main methods.

(a) Using coordinating conjunctions (and, but, or, so, yet)

It was raining. We went out. - It was raining, but we went out.

(b) Using subordinating conjunctions (because, although, if, when, while, since, unless)

- *He was tired. He kept working. - Although he was tired, he kept working.*
- *The road was blocked. We were late. - We were late because the road was blocked.*

(c) Using relative pronouns (who, whom, which, that, whose)

- *I met a man. He teaches music. - I met a man who teaches music.*
- *This is the book. I bought it yesterday. - This is the book that I bought yesterday.*

(d) Using participles, infinitives and phrases

- **Present participle:** *She opened the door. She walked in. - Opening the door, she walked in.*
- **Past participle:** *He was tired by the work. He fell asleep. - Tired by the work, he fell asleep.*
- **Infinitive:** *He went to the market. He wanted to buy fruit. - He went to the market to buy fruit.*
- **too ... to / so ... that:** *He is too weak to walk. = He is so weak that he cannot walk.*
- **Appositive:** *Kalam was a scientist. He became President. - Kalam, a scientist, became President.*

Remember: Choose the connector that matches the relation: addition (and), contrast (but, although), reason (because), result (so), condition (if), time (when, after).

9. Vowel and Consonant Sounds

English has **26 letters** but about **44 sounds** in standard British pronunciation (Received Pronunciation). Spelling is not a reliable guide: the letters 'ough' are pronounced differently in *though, through, tough, cough*. Sounds are shown in the dictionary using the **International Phonetic Alphabet (IPA)** between slanted lines.

Vowel sounds: 20 in all (12 pure vowels + 8 diphthongs)

A vowel sound is made with the air passing freely through the mouth without blocking. The position of the tongue and the shape of the lips decide the sound.

Pure vowel	Example	Pure vowel	Example
/iː/	see, team, key	/ɪ/	sit, big
/e/	bed, many	/æ/	cat, black
/ɑː/	car, father	/ɒ/	hot, dog
/ɔː/	saw, door	/ʊ/	put, book
/uː/	food, blue	/ʌ/	cup, love
/ɜː/	bird, turn	/ə/	about, teacher (the weak 'schwa')

Long vowels (marked with the length sign) are held longer than short ones: *sheep* /ʃiːp/ and *ship* /ʃɪp/ are different words.

Diphthong	Example	Diphthong	Example
/eɪ/	day, make	/aɪ/	high, my
/ɔɪ/	boy, coin	/əʊ/	go, home
/aʊ/	now, house	/ɪə/	here, ear
/eə/	hair, care	/ʊə/	tour, pure

A **diphthong** is a glide: the voice begins at one vowel and moves smoothly towards another within one syllable.

Consonant sounds: 24 in all

A consonant sound is made when the air is partly or fully blocked by the tongue, teeth or lips. Consonants are described by **voicing** (do the vocal cords vibrate?), **place** (where) and **manner** (how).

Group	Voiceless	Voiced
Plosives (air stopped, then released)	/p/ pen, /t/ tea, /k/ cat	/b/ bad, /d/ dog, /g/ go
Fricatives (air rubs through a narrow gap)	/f/ fan, /θ/ think, /s/ sun, /ʃ/ she, /h/ hat	/v/ van, /ð/ this, /z/ zoo, /ʒ/ vision
Affricates (plosive + fricative)	/tʃ/ chair	/dʒ/ judge
Nasals (air through the nose)	-	/m/ man, /n/ no, /ŋ/ sing
Approximants (liquids and glides)	-	/l/ light, /r/ red, /w/ we, /j/ yes

Common difficulties for Indian learners

- **/θ/ and /ð/** (think, this) are often said as t or d. Place the tongue lightly between the teeth and let air flow.
- **/v/ and /w/:** *vine* and *wine* are different. For /v/, the upper teeth touch the lower lip; for /w/, only the lips are rounded.
- **/p, t, k/** are aspirated (a small puff of air) at the start of a stressed syllable in English: *pen*, *tea*, *cat*.
- Do not add a vowel before consonant clusters: say *school*, not 'iskool'; *station*, not 'istation'.
- Silent letters: k in *knife*, b in *doubt*, w in *write*, l in *half*, h in *hour*.

10. Word Stress

A **syllable** is a unit of sound with one vowel sound (*to-day* has 2; *com-pu-ter* has 3). In any English word of more than one syllable, one syllable is **stressed**: it is said louder, longer and with a higher pitch. The others are weaker. Wrong stress can make a word hard to understand even when each sound is correct. In dictionaries, stress is marked before the stressed syllable.

Rule	Examples (stressed syllable in capitals)
Most two-syllable nouns and adjectives: stress on the first syllable	TAble, TEAcher, HAPpy, CLEver
Most two-syllable verbs: stress on the second syllable	deCIDE, beGIN, reLAX, preSENT (verb)
Words ending in -tion, -sion, -ic, -ical, -ity, -ify, -graphy: stress on the syllable just before the ending	eduCAtion, eCOnomic, poliTIcal, caPAcity, phoTOgraphy
Compound nouns: stress on the first part	BLACKboard, GREENhouse
Compound adjectives and verbs: stress on the second part	bad-TEMpered, underSTAND
Stress can change a noun to a verb	REcord (noun) - reCORD (verb); PREsent - preSENT; OBject - obJECT
Words with prefixes: stress usually stays on the root	unHAPpy, reTURN

Practice: Look up ten new words every week in a dictionary with audio, note the stress, and say them aloud.

11. Sentence Stress

In a sentence, not all words are equally important. **Content words** carry the meaning and are stressed: nouns, main verbs, adjectives, adverbs, negatives and question words. **Function words** are the grammar words and are usually unstressed and quick: articles, prepositions, auxiliaries, pronouns and conjunctions. This gives English its rhythm: stressed syllables come at roughly regular intervals, and the weak words are squeezed between them.

Example
Normal stress: I want to BUY a NEW BOOK from the SHOP.
Weak forms: 'to' is said /tə/, 'a' is said /ə/, 'from' is said /frəm/.

You can also stress a particular word to change the meaning (**emphatic stress**):

Sentence with emphasis	Meaning
I did not take your pen.	Someone else took it.
I did not **take** your pen.	I only borrowed it or saw it.
I did not take **your** pen.	I took someone else's pen.
I did not take your **pen**.	I took something else of yours.

12. Intonation

Intonation is the rise and fall of the voice (pitch) across a phrase or sentence. It is the 'music' of speech. It tells the listener whether you are asking or telling, whether you are sure or doubtful, and what your attitude is: happy, angry, polite or bored. The same words said with different intonation can have different meanings.

Pattern	When it is used	Example
Falling (voice goes down at the end)	Statements, commands, wh-questions (what, where, why), and to show certainty	I live in PuduCHERry. (falls) / Where do you LIVE? (falls)
Rising (voice goes up at the end)	Yes/no questions, polite requests, showing surprise or doubt	Are you COMing? (rises) / Really? (rises)
Fall-rise	Hesitation, reservation, polite correction	Well, I SUPpose so... (it may not be good)
Rising in lists	Items in a list rise; the final item falls	I bought apples (up), oranges (up), and BAnanas (down).
Tag questions	Rising if you are really asking; falling if you expect agreement	It's cold, isn't it? (falling = I expect you agree)

Tip: A flat voice with no intonation sounds bored. Use a wider pitch range when you want to sound interested and friendly.

13. Practice in Pronunciation

- **Listen and repeat:** imitate clear speakers in news bulletins, podcasts and audio dictionaries. Repeat short phrases aloud.
- **Use a good dictionary:** check IPA, stress and audio for every new word.
- **Minimal pairs:** practise words that differ by only one sound: ship / sheep, bit / beat, pull / pool, think / sink, vine / wine, bad / bed.

- **Tongue twisters:** 'She sells sea shells on the sea shore.' / 'Peter Piper picked a peck of pickled peppers.' Start slowly and increase speed.
- **Record and compare:** record yourself reading a paragraph, then compare with a model speaker and correct the differences.
- **Read aloud daily** for 10 minutes, watching stress and intonation.
- **Slow down:** clear speech is better than fast speech.
- **Mirror practice:** watch the movement of your lips and tongue.